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OVERFLOW TURNOUT AT 2nd POLICE RACISM HEARING

(Oakland, Calif.) — An overflow crowd of nearly 200 North Oakland residents, mostly Black but with a sizable number of Whites, heard 13 persons testify to acts of police brutality, harassment, intimidation and blatant racism at the second community public hearing before the special City Council committee investigating charges of police racism on Monday, May 12 at Evergreen Baptist Church.

Oakland residents filled the hall, stood around the walls and spilled out onto the church plaza. The hearings began a little after the scheduled 7:30 p.m. Councilmen Joshua Rose, chairman of the committee, Joe Coto and George Vukasin (who arrived nearly one-half hour after the meeting opened) constitute the special committee.

Councilman Rose opened the meeting, and Pastor J. Alfred Smith, of Allen Temple Baptist Church and chief spokesperson for the Community Coalition on Police Racism introduced Rev. J.L. Richards, pastor of Evergreen Baptist Church, who offered a prayer.

Pastor Smith got the hearings off to a rousing start with a blast at Oakland Mayor John Reading for his reported assertion that he (Pastor Smith) and NAACP Executive Director Alphonso Galloway were engaged in a "witchhunt" against the Oakland Police Department. Pastor Smith emphasized that he and Brother Galloway were not acting

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Attentive overflow crowd listens as Brother JOSEPH STEVENSON (standing, left), a disabled veteran of three American wars, describes police brutality he recently witnessed against a Black man in downtown Oakland.

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